

What's the FOSS about?

The inaugural issue of the International Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) Law Review launched recently. It will be a forum for discussions on issues regarding best practices in open source and FOSS implementation.



in OS Operating Systems and eventually morph into full-featured and competitive end-user graphics cards. The first board prototype dubbed OGD1, is an FPGA chip. Field Programmable Gate Arrays (FPGAs) can have their circuit pattern altered by programming, much like a Flash memory chip. Thus the circuit itself is firmware. The trouble is that such a board will be very expensive. But once the chips are out, developers will be able to try out their existing 3D acceleration designs. Once a stable enough design is created and tested, the cards can be mass manufactured.

The BUGlabs project is another interesting open source hardware platform. It can best be described as Lego for the serious geek. These are basically modular computing devices that can be programmed and attached to each other to make devices that perform specialised specific tasks. The main building block, or the central piece, comes with an ARM processor (530 MHz), memory (128 MB), a rechargeable battery and several ports where other bug devices can be attached. The device can then be modded to perform tasks by attaching modules; say a motion sensor module for some security purpose. The modules available from the company include GPS, camera,

a niche audience comprised of technology enthusiasts. All information relating to the project such as schematics and CAD files have been released into the public arena under open licences to be further modified and redistributed.

The CEO of OpenMoko, Mr. Sean Moss-Pultz has coined an interesting phrase for this phenomenon. He calls it "social electronics" – an approach that bridges the gap between the developer community and consumers. The project has been quite successful, with multiple widget kits and UI interfaces already developed to run on the OpenMoko hardware.

Open science

Traditionally, scientists have been known to be very secretive about their research until it is finalised and published. But things are slowly changing and many initiatives have sprung up that mirror the open source way of doing things. There are many databases set up that provide open access to the scientific community and students alike, to be able to access information for research. Why did the conservative scientific community that would earlier thrive on "eureka" breakthroughs decide to go open? Perhaps

the telescoping nature of scientific advancement in today's era made research stagnant and there was no other option than to pool resources. When it comes to publication of

scientific research, a notable project is the Budapest Open Access Initiative (www.soros.org/openaccess). So what kind of material is available here? As the site explains "BOAI makes an explicit and fundamental distinction between writings that scientists and scholars do and do not wish to give away for free. BOAI applies only to the former. The objective is that readers should not have to pay access tolls

to read them." And though this project facilitates free access, scientists still retain copyrights, and citing references pointing to sources is important when using any of it. Then there is lalisio.com, that calls itself a social knowledge network. It allows registered users to exchange "Grey Literature", which includes access to each others papers, idea outlines and slides.

Open source kitchen sink

Open source has reached so many different facets of life that experiments with the concept are taking place in almost every field. There's open source education, wherein a category of community developed study material has evolved called OSC (open source

DID YOU KNOW?

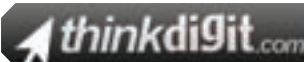
There is another project called Open Beer Project, that basically facilitates meetings between geeks from all over the world over a mug of beer. The concept, says the website (openbeer.dk), is this: "If you know you are going somewhere, you check if anyone you know from IRC lives there. If anyone whom you would care to meet lives there, arrange a meeting. When you get there, you meet and drink beer in a joint appointed by the local geek.

and screens for added functionality. The open source hardware project is enabling a new generation of engineers to tap their creativity and build any type of device they want, without having to solder, learn solid state electronics, or "go to China" as it says on its web site. Snap on gadget building – that's the concept. Arduino is similar open-source physical computing platform with a development environment for writing software for the board. For more details visit www.arduino.cc.

OpenMoko Smartphone is a notable project aimed at building an open source smartphone that could rival the likes of the iPhone. The project has run into trouble recently thanks to the plummeting economy. The company backing the project had to hand over the entire project, including the brand name, to the developer community, but it will still provide limited support. The OpenMoko phone is meant for

curriculum). OSC signifies any online instructional resource that can be used for free, is free to distribute and can be modified. The seminal work in this field dates back to 2003 with MIT starting the OpenCourseWare project. This provided students with open access to class syllabuses, and lecture notes amongst other resources. Another project, known as the Global Education and Learning Community, is busy bringing out online books and other curriculum material for students from kindergarten up to class 12. A similar project that has managed to create over 10,000 pages of curriculum is being used successfully by a school district in Alaska. The same benefits of open source collaboration, are realised here – content that is produced is of the highest quality, up to date (obsolescence is a major affliction for text books), and led by a community of dedicated educators. Through the free and open source philosophy, there has emerged what economists are beginning to call a "new segment of global public goods". According to them, even simple comments we make on YouTube, forums and message boards, are part of the fabric of the global collective.

Those comments together make a product; they enhance the original product and form an integral part of the sum total of human knowledge. In a world where there is growing distrust of corporate entities and restrictive IP rights, the ownership of knowledge and how we use it will define the next era of development. Who knows, open source may some day lead us to a Utopian society of abundance, freedom and liberty only envisaged by philosophers. 



Discuss this article at
www.thinkdigit.com/d/62007

DIGIT'S OPEN SOURCE PROJECT

In a first of its kind project Digit plans to crowd source its January Fast Track (FT) to our very vibrant and active community. The FT to Trouble Shooting Your PC, will be developed piece by piece, under the control of digit readers and forum community. The community has been very active lately, especially in giving us a lot of constructive criticism for the Fast Track. So, what we figure is it's time to come together, and build a better product – collaboratively. You get to create, collaborate, and control everything from cover to the contents. Each and every one who contributes meaningfully to the project (for instance with answering even a small trouble shooting query) will get a mention in the Fast Track. Project details will be released soon on www.thinkdigit.com/digitosp